

RESELL OR RECYCLE

THERE'S AN UNTAPPED GOLDMINE WAITING TO BE EXPLOITED FOR THE GOOD OF THE ENVIRONMENT

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

India is a massive market for smartphones, one that's steadily growing despite the economic slowdown that's occurring. In Q3 2019, manufacturers shipped 49 million smartphones in India which is somewhat to the tune of a 10% Year-on-Year growth. It's understandable how folks keep buying more of these smartphones and replace them every few months. According to some statistics, folks tend to switch smartphones every 15 months. That's a lot of smartphones that are either being sold in the second-hand market, sent back to the manufacturer for recycling or, worse, simply being dumped in some landfill. The Associated Chambers of Commerce and Industry of India (ASSOCHAM) released a report citing the Compounded Annual Growth Rate of electronic waste being 30%. And if you look at the bigger picture then 70% of this e-waste is made up of computers, 12% is from the telecom market, 8% is from the medical sector and 7% is constituted of electric goods. Most of this comes from companies which account for 75% of all the e-waste generated in the country. Private individuals only

contribute about 16%. So where does all this waste go?

THE ENVIRONMENT, OF COURSE!

Given the lax rules that we have, companies don't have to take much effort into keeping a check on their e-waste pollution levels. The first e-waste legislation was enacted in 1986, in the form



of the Environmental Protection Act and then later bolstered in 2011, 2016 and 2018. It would appear that we were late to the party. The Indian e-waste management sector is very unorganised and as a result, the folks who have the equipment and can do things the right way, cannot compete and turn a

profit. The unorganised folks tend to make use of cheap methods to extract whatever materials they want from the e-waste and these cheap methods are often a source of pollution on their own. Open burning, acid baths, machine shredding, etc. are some of the unsophisticated but economical methods employed by the unorganised sector. This begs the question - what's the formal sector doing?

RECOMMERCE

Given that folks in India switch smartphones every 15 months on average, and then there's the whole cultural aspect of handing gadgets down to others rather than dumping them, there's a large market for second-hand goods. Given the informal nature of this market as well, we've seen many companies enter the space hoping to cash in. This is termed the recommerce market and then there are the ones who recycle e-waste on your behalf. They have all the proper equipment to dismantle and extract the materials that can be reused as well as the materials that need to be disposed of in a proper manner.